EW 5 Pronouns

28. Pronouns

A pronoun is a word which stands in place of a noun. In French the pronoun must have the same number and gender as the noun it replaces. There are two categories of pronoun, conjunctive and disjunctive, which will be explained in the following sections, but with all pronouns you must know whether a verb takes *à* or *de* or is followed directly by an object before you can determine which type of pronoun to use.

Reflexive pronouns are conjunctive pronouns. See the section on Reflexive Verbs

29. Conjunctive pronouns

The word *conjunctive* is derived from the Latin words meaning *with* and *to join*. All the pronouns in this section are those which must be closely allied to verbs; they cannot stand on their own, away from a verb.

The position of conjunctive pronouns

RULE: always in front of a verb, except in a positive command. If the verb is in a compound tense, the pronoun will always go in front of the auxiliary verb.

a) Pronouns with all verbs that are followed directly by an object in French (ie no *à* or *de*)

Verbs of this type are *voir*, *écouter*, *donner*, *attendre*, *frapper*, *remarquer*, *emmener*,

The pronouns used are *me*, *te*, *le*, *la*, *nous*, *vous*, *les* and they can be used to replace people or things.

Because these are direct object pronouns there will always be an agreement of the past participle when they are used with verbs in compound tenses taking *avoir*

Il a envoyé les lettres	→	*Il les a envoyées*
J'ai vu les enfants jouer	→	*Je les ai vus jouer*

b) Pronouns with non-reflexive verbs which are followed by *à*

Verbs of this type are *téléphoner*, *dire*, *parler*, *demander*, *permettre*, *promettre*, *ordonner*, *conseiller*

The pronouns used for **PEOPLE** are **me, te, lui, nous, vous, leur**
The pronoun used for **THINGS** is **y**

These indirect object pronouns never force a past participle agreement in compound tenses.

Il a parlé à sa femme	→	*Il lui a parlé*
Nous conseillons aux enfants	→	*Nous leur conseillons*

c) Order of pronouns when two are used with the same verb - though see below for commands

1	2	3	4	5
me				
te	le	lui	y	en
se	la	leur		
nous	les			
vous				

Read the columns in numerical order to discover the order of pronouns.

en will be explained in a later section

Il a passé la balle à Marie	→	*Il la lui a passée* (agreement from *la*, not from *lui*)
Elle a donné les fleurs à ses parents	→	*Elle les leur a données*

d) The above pronouns used in commands

POSITIVE COMMANDS

- The pronouns come after the verb and are joined with hyphens.
- The order is always verb-direct object-indirect object.
- **me changes to moi; te changes to toi**

Donne la bouteille à Paul	→	*Donne-la-lui!*
Send it (= bottle) to me	→	*Envoyez-la-moi!*

NEGATIVE COMMANDS

- The pronouns come before the verb in the order shown in paragraph (c)
- **moi changes back to me; toi changes back to te**

Donnez-la-lui	→	*Ne la lui donnez pas!*
Envoyez-la-moi	→	*Ne me l'envoyez pas!*

30. Disjunctive pronouns

These are pronouns that can be dis-joined. Sometimes they stand alone. They are used in a different way from conjunctive pronouns in that, when used with verbs, they follow a preposition even when used in a command.

a) Pronouns used with reflexive verbs followed by *à* or *de*, and non-reflexive verbs followed by *de*

Verbs of this type are *se fier à, s'adresser à, s'intéresser à*
se moquer de, s'occuper de, se souvenir de, s'approcher de, se servir de
rire de, rêver de, avoir pitié de, se méfier de

The pronouns used for **PEOPLE** are **moi, toi, lui, elle, nous, vous eux, elles**

The pronoun used for **THINGS** is **en** (when the verb takes *de*) or **y** (when the verb takes *à*)

I trusted him	→	*je me suis fié à lui*
Do you remember us?	→	*Est-ce que tu te souviens de nous?*
I dreamt about her	→	*J'ai rêvé d'elle*

I dreamt about it	→	*J'en ai rêvé*
We remembered it	→	*Nous nous en sommes souvenu(e)s*

b) Disjunctive pronouns are also used with the following verbs - and only these verbs

courir, *venir*, *aller*, *faire attention à*, *faire appel à* (to appeal to), *penser à*, *songer à* (to muse on)

We ran to them	→	*Nous avons couru à eux / elles*
We ran to it	→	*Nous y avons couru*
They paid us no attention	→	*Il n'ont pas fait attention à nous*
Do you think about me?	→	*Penses-tu à moi?*
Do you think about it	→	*Y penses-tu?*

The vast majority of verbs taking *à* + noun use the conjunctive pronouns before the verb. The verbs above are the **ONLY** exceptions.

c) Other uses of disjunctive pronouns

i) **With a preposition** *Il était assis en face de moi*

ii) **In comparisons** *Marie est moins belle qu'elle*

iii) **In order to emphasise** a subject the French often use *c'est*

I told you	*C'est moi qui vous l'ai dit*
He saw me	*C'est lui qui m'a vu*

As an alternative, the following emphatic forms may be used:

moi je	*toi tu*	*lui* or *elle* (NEVER *lui il* or *elle elle*)
nous nous	*vous vous*	*eux* or *elles* (NEVER *eux ils* or *elles elles*)

They will tell you *Eux vous le diront*

iv) **To stand alone**

Who did it? Him or her? *Qui l'a fait? Lui ou elle?*

v) With *à* To indicate possession *Cette radio est à moi* (=mine)

vi) As part of a compound subject *Julien et moi sommes partis*
Paul et lui sont allés à la pêche

vii) **With *c'est* or *ce sont*** to convey the idea of "it's ...."

c'est moi	*c'est toi*	*c'est lui*	*c'est elle*
c'est nous	*c'est vous*	*ce **sont** eux*	*ce **sont** elles*

viii) **Combined with *-même(s)*** for further strengthening

I did it myself	*Je l'ai fait moi-même*
We did it ourselves	*Nous l'avons fait nous-mêmes*

31. Soi

Soi is ONLY used when the subject of the sentence is one of *on*, *chacun*, *personne*, or *tout le monde*, and with impersonal verbs

You must not think just of yourself	*Il ne faut pas penser qu'à soi*
Every man for himself	*chacun pour soi*
Everyone goes home at 6 o'clock	*tout le monde rentre chez soi à 6h*

32. Note the following idiomatic constructions:

i) **French does not translate "it" in cases such as the following**

to find/judge/think/deem/consider it + adjective + to do sthg

He found it impossible to understand it	*Il a trouvé impossible de le comprendre*
We thought it unwise to stay	*Nous avons jugé imprudent de rester*

ii) **French INSERTS *le* with *dire, savoir, croire, penser, vouloir, espérer***

when they have neither direct object nor dependent *que* clause

You have already told me	*Tu me l'as déjà dit*
As you know	*Comme vous le savez*

iii) **French inserts *le* with *être* where there is an adjective understood or implied**

He is rich, *she* is not	*Lui est riche, elle ne l'est pas*

iv) **French INSERTS 'en'**

(a) with a number or expression of quantity NOT FOLLOWED by a noun

-He took several/afew/too many/four:
-Il en a pris plusieurs/quelques-un(e)s/trop/quatre

(b) with *d'autres* not followed by a noun

-I saw others *-J'en ai vu d'autres*

(**NB** there is no agreement when the verb takes *avoir* in compound tenses)

(c) with *sortir & descendre* where the place from which the person came out/got out has just been mentioned

-A woman got out/came out *-Une femme en est descendue/sortie*

33. For reference

- The verbs in the following table are the only ones to use disjunctive pronouns moi, toi, lui, elle etc

VERB	EXAMPLES
a) **courir, venir & aller**	*J'ai couru à elle*
b) **faire attention à, faire appel à** (to appeal to)	*Tu ne fais jamais attention à moi*
c) **penser à & songer à**	*Il pensait à elle*
d) **ALL Reflexive verbs that take *à* or *de* + noun**	*Je me fie à lui* *Il se moque d'eux*
e) **ALL non-Reflexive verbs that take *de* + noun**	*J'ai rêvé de vous* *Il a ri de moi*

- All other verbs use conjunctive pronouns *me, te, le, la* etc and *me, te, lui* etc
- You must know whether the verb takes nothing, *à* or *de* before the noun to decide which pronouns to use
- If the verb takes *à* before the noun use *y* to stand for THINGS; if it takes *de*, use *en*